

Beyond The Glitz of Popularity: Women Managers In The Popular Yoruba Travelling Theatre

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The Yoruba Travelling Theatre (YTT) is 'one of the most vigorous, widely popular and thriving theatre traditions in modern Africa' between late 1940s and 1980s (Jeyifo, 1984: p.27)¹. It is a commercialized and professional theatrical tradition with innumerable troupes that travelled round towns and villages to showcase and narrate the rich cultural heritage of the Yoruba society that created it. A theatre Awam Amkpa (2004) aptly describes as 'the most populist dramaturgy Nigeria ever experienced' had a huge audience attraction, and references were made to their performances and the actors' ingenuities in homes, media and high places (p.77)². The popularity the YTT enjoyed was not without its attendant price. The paper, therefore, examines the theatre as a popular culture which was mainly staffed and structured by an economic mindset of a family house system. It also assesses how the wives of the theatre owners managed the troupes to become successful medium of interaction between a crossbreed of audience in nooks and crannies of Nigeria and beyond.

Keywords: Women in Theatre, Women Managers and Yoruba Travelling Theatre.

The Beginning

Many scholars have established that the Yoruba theatre emerged from the dramatic roots of the *egungun* worship and later as court entertainers (Adededeji, 1981, p.221)³. In the course of years that followed, that is, several decades after the colonial encounter and before independence, traditional music was no longer limited to the *egungun* cult or ritual worship and theatre

¹Jeyifo, B, *The Yoruba Popular Travelling Theatre* (Lagos: Nigeria Magazine, Publication, 1984) p. 27.

²Amkpa, A. (2004). *Theatre and Postcolonial Desires* (London: Routledge, 2004), p.77.

Adededeji, J.A. (1981). 'Alarinjo': The Traditional Yoruba Travelling Theatre', in Yemi

³Ogunbiyi, (Ed.), *Drama and Theatre in Nigeria: A Critical Source Book* (Nigeria Magazine Publishers, 1981), p. p. 221.

was highly visible in churches through operatic performances called 'cantata' and some of the choir-masters moved it out of the church into public places like the Lisabi Hall, Ebute Metta and Glover Memorial Hall, Lagos. This new form of theatre, 'Concert Party', became a movement that was popular with names such as A.B. David, A.A. Ayeni, P.A. Dawodu and later Hubert Ogunde commercialized it for the pleasure of paying audience. However, touring theatre groups started when P.A. Dawodu's party based in Ibadan went round the Western provinces with *King Ahab and Naboth's Garden* and was later followed by Ogunde's party which became the first professional troupe to travel out of Lagos and tour the other provinces of Nigeria with *Adam and Eve* (Adedeji, 1969, p.369, p.372)⁴. Seeing the success of Ogunde's Concert Party; other troupes sprang up like those of Kola Ogunmola, Duro Ladipo, Oyin Adejobi and Moses Adejumo, but during that period in Nigerian society, there were social stigma associated with performing troupes; the artistes were regarded as 'Alarinjo', a name that originated as an abuse, and were also labeled as rogues, vagabonds and sturdy beggars' (Adedeji 1969, p.191)⁵.

Consequently, parents abhorred seeing their children have any contact with the theatre or its practitioners. The boys or men were able to easily overcome or cope with these depreciatory tags by joining the troupes *en masse*, but the societal norms were very strict and not permissible for ladies in those days. It was, therefore, hard to get ladies to act and dance in a commercial theatre troupe. Hence, Ogunde, whose troupe was impeded by the absence of these female performers, decided to marry all his actresses to run his theatre business and to keep them away from further reproach.

Successively, Ogunde staffed and structured his theatre outfit by an economic mind set of a family house system which conforms to Engel's submission (1972) that the family is primarily an economic entity rather than a biological one. Falola (2001, p.117)⁶ advances the economic stress within a family when he describes the family as 'a social unit where members share not only residence but maintenance of the household,' and the 'management of

⁴Adedeji, J.A. 'Traditional Yoruba Theatre', in *African Arts*, Vol. 3, No. 1 Autumn, (1969), p. 372.

⁵Ibid., p. 191.

⁶Falola, T, *Culture and Customs of Nigeria* (Westport: Greenwood Press, 2001) p. 117.

economic matters...' This style was copied by most of the troupe leaders who, apart from being the legal owners and artistic impresario of the various troupes, were also the patriarchs within the groups (Jeyifo, 1984, p.87)⁷. They married many of their lead actresses and co-opted their children into the theatre business, so the troupes were either kith and Kin, or lineage based (Olaniyan 2007, p.357)⁸.

This form of management is similar to the one found in traditional occupations where 'the family serves as the primary economic unit to produce and consume goods and sell their surplus to meet their other needs' (Falola, p.117)⁹. Ogunde also succinctly justified this style as a traditional technique of management (Jeyifo, 1984, p.89)¹⁰, and facsimile of the farming style amongst Yoruba people, which makes the entire family responsible for its success. A typical Yoruba farmer would marry numerous women to aid his farming business and maintain his large household. Duro Ladipo, like other troupe leaders, also made people around him - his four wives, nephews, cousins and friends - advance his artistic interest.

The women were married to the troupe leaders and made to work assiduously in all the areas of the theatre, mostly and sometimes not employing division of labour. They handled multiple elements of the theatre in the areas of acting, dancing, designing costumes, selling of tickets, manning the gates as ticket takers, and operating confectionery stands. This style of inclusiveness and integral totality of the Travelling Theatre performance idiom (Music, Dance, Mime and Dialogue) has engendered rather unique patterns of structure and detail in the construction of the performances (Jeyifo, 1984, p.15)¹¹.

The Managerial Duties

Byrnes (2003, p.31)¹² explains that a theatre manager must have a personal mission that drives him which he calls "passion":

⁷Jeyifo, op. cit., p. 87.

⁸Olaniyan, T. & Quayson A, (Eds.) *African Literature: An Anthology of Criticism and Theory* (USA: Blackwell Publishing, 2007) p. 357.

⁹Falola, op. cit., p. 117 .

¹⁰Jeyifo, op. cit., p. 89.

¹¹Ibid., p. 15

¹²Byrnes, W, *Management and the Arts* (Oxford: Focal Press 2003), p. 31.

As essential ingredient in the mix of the knowledge skills and abilities that a person brings to any arts management job must include a passion for what he or she is doing and a strong sense of purpose. The challenges in this field are many. Therefore, a strong personal mission and sense of purpose is an important part of the profile of an arts manager.

This explanation can be used to project the way the women were undaunted in their pursuit of managing the troupes. Beyond this generalization and multiplicity of duties, the women had inherent attitude of handling the core functional areas of theatre management – planning, organizing, staffing, and controlling. They basically assisted in organizing human and material resources to help the troupes achieve their stated goals and objectives.



Yetunde Ogunsola

For some troupes such as Isola Ogunsola Theatre, the job of the women usually starts with publicity. Yetunde was the Booking Manager for a period of time and did almost all of the fixings for performances. She usually went round to book venues long before the troupe moved out of their Ibadan base. Having pasted posters around the town days or weeks before the troupe's arrival at the designated town of performance, a normal schedule of duty on the performance day starts with a guerilla-like publicity, which does not exempt the women. Some of them sit on top of the lorry dancing to percussion coming from drums placed inside the vehicle with someone speaking over the megaphone in rhythmical synchronisation to announce the arrival of the team and updating the people of the time, venue and gate fee. There was even a case of one of the actresses married to Hubert Ogunde – late Risikat Adeite (Mama Demola) - who sometimes drove the company's lorry round the town for publicity while the men sat comfortably to do the drumming and announcing. They were so astute in filling such gaps in the day to day running of the troupes.

In Ojo Ladipo Theatre troupe, after the demise of the leader, Ojo, and the taking over of the reins of the company by the trio of Adebayo Salami (Oga Bello), Sunday Omobolanle (Aluwe), and Lanre Hassan (Mama Awero), the latter stated that she became the one in charge of the administration of the troupe; seeing to the day to day running and keeping the fiscal details which afforded the team to have a stable outfit called Awada Kerikeri. This, however, did not exempt her from the guerilla publicity stunts before performances. It is also pertinent to note that at the beginning of this new era in their troupe, they went all out to source for sponsorship among well-meaning Nigerians to continue operating. She explains that:

Adebayo Salami led a team that went to banks, companies and any organisations to get deals. This renaissance era saw us doing flow shows, propaganda sketches, end of the year parties, AGM of companies and even churches. It was the men that did the aggressive marketing. I just sat at the office to take care of the administrative matters



Lanre Hassan (Mama Awero)

But in the Oyin Adejobi Theatre, Kareem Adepoju (Baba Wande) was the in-house troupe manager that handled all administrative duties and the troupe members. This allowed the women the time to face other managerial duties such as the box office – selling and taking of tickets, controlling the admission of the audience into the theatre, and house management. All of these they did in addition to manning the sweetshop - selling of snacks and sweets to the audience before the show (Barber, 2000, p.93)¹³. For Baba Sala troupe, the women were in charge of the confectionary mobile shop in which they took turns to handle. Moses Olaiya stopped the act when it became highly contentious.

The women also managed the tours, most especially in the area of welfare which was usually done on meager funds. They made sure the artistes and their children who were on tour with them are fed with whatever was available just to make it to the next point of performance. One of the women

¹³Barber, K, *The Generation of Plays: Yoruba Popular Life in Theatre* (Bloomington: Indiana University Press, 2000), p. 93.

narrated how they harvested maize for free from people's farms without taking proper permission. They usually ate such food crops without the fear of the unknown. Yetunde Ogunsola said there were days it was yam they would harvest from any farm without the owner's consent because of hunger. She said, "in any case, we managed ourselves and we survived."

Having acquired the skills for total theatre as a member of the YTT for twenty-six years, Iyabo Ogunsola of the Isola Ogunsola Theatre states that:

I continued managing the group after Isola died and the troupe is still functioning till date. We gather ourselves together whenever we have any performance and we disband again when we are done. The troupe is still called

Isola Ogunsola Theatre and we are presently into film productions.



Iyabo Ogunsola (Efunsetan Aniwura)

For the Ogunsolas, Samson Eluwole (Jinadu Ewele) was the troupe manager of the troupe until the untimely demise of Isola. Afterwards, Iyabo, as the most senior wife after Mojisola's demise, assumed the leadership of the troupe to have proper control of the activities of the troupe whenever they have to work together.

Women and Costume Designing in YTT

According to Banham, 'the populist aesthetics of YTT performances was built on loose improvisation, the spectacles of props and costume, lively and engaging musical ensemble and the socio-political and cultural relevance of its content' (p.150)¹⁴. This concept of creativity is a common denominator found in the works of the various artists of the YTT; hence, their performances were characterized with spectacular sets, brilliant and colourful costumes. Costume designing in the theatre is highly demanding because when other theatre personnel had stopped working, the designers still continue to sort and arrange used costumes for inventory-taking and proper keeps. Costuming requires flexibility, artistic ingenuity coupled with strenuous schedule. The women also doubled as costume designers for their various troupes and they put in longer hours at painstaking detailed work of building the costumes and accessories. Lanre Hassan, the costume designer for Awada Kerikeri Theatre group at inception till the present day states that:

My role from the beginning was to handle costumes because every person had their other responsibilities apart from acting. So I combined costuming with the administration of the troupe, which made us very strong and versatile.

She further attests to the fact that to be a professional costume designer, there is the need to know the art of draping, sewing, and patterning. All of these were employed in her works as she designed costumes for all of her troupe's stage productions; a task she combined with wardrobe job. When 'a commercially vibrant medium, cinematic/filmic art captured the imagination of the practitioners of live theatre of the vernacular mode' (Banham, p.150)¹⁵ and her troupe joined with their blockbuster film, *Ogun Ajaye* (1985); it was easy and smooth for her to translate to film genre having worked with late Adeite Risikat (Hubert Ogunde's wife) to handle the costumes used for all of Ogunde's films: *Aiye* (1980), *Jayesimi* (1981), and *Aropin N'Tenia* (1982). She later on worked on the sets of Ogunde's last film, *Ayanmo* (1986), as well as Awada Kerikeri's *Omo Orukan* (1987), *Asewo to re Mecca* (1992), *Rich Man dey Mess* (year of production unknown) and Ojojolu Film Empire's epic film, *Oduduwa* (2000).

¹⁴Banham, M (Ed.), *A History of Theatre in Africa* (UK: Cambridge University Press, 2004) p. 150.

¹⁵Ibid.

For some of the women, the arts of costuming were learnt as hands-on, while few were already seamstresses before the joining the troupes. All of these became added advantage for the troupes and their leaders for they had no reason to look for creative artistes, pattern cutters, sewers, shoppers, buyers, negotiators and wardrobe managers in the costumes section. When they are not designing the costumes, they sourced for them by pulling from members of the troupe and in the case of large productions such as *Efunsetan* which is a traditional drama piece, one of the women usually serve as the design supervisor while others sew and mend the ones in their stock.

They shop for accessories at local markets, which they later on assemble into unit to fit whatever play they are working on. All these are kept in their wardrobe for pickups as expected in wardrobe management in a repertory theatre. Yetunde, who was the Booking Manager of Ogunsola's troupe also doubled as the wardrobe mistress as she took charge of the laundry, racking, and inventory of the costumes; an art she also got from working with the Ogunde's wives on their film projects. For the Adejobi's theatre, Grace's (the most senior wife of Oyin) expertise at dress-making which she had been doing before she got married to her husband was put to use. Though the troupe mostly made use of the artistes' personal wears for contemporary stories, she worked on the traditional costumes used for cultural based productions.

In Duro Ladipo National Theatre, the leader had some tailors who sew most of the costumes, but this was done under the supervision of Abiodun and other wives. Abiodun states that one of her preoccupation in the troupe is to design appropriate garbs and accessories that each character in their plays wear and this is still on today because she solely designed and stringed the beads (neck, hands, and leg) used by her daughter, Solabomi Duro-Ladipo Akinsola in the role of Moremi in the film of the same title. Abiodun is also known to be her own hairdresser, an art she honed in making hair for troupe members for several years. When asked how she goes about it, she says she cannot explain but that whatever anyone does regularly becomes easy to do.

The women worked on the costumes that aided the audience's focus on the content and style of the plays while giving structure to the director's work. Some of the costumes designed could sometimes be symbolic to create archetypes or individualistic such as characters found in the generality of

people in a cast of some actors/founders/managers whose beginning had been traced to the Alarinjo tradition of old.

Producing

While the women were still under their husbands and leaders, there was no room to solely create their own works or showcase their producing abilities. The room to do this became opened after the demise of their leaders and husbands. The passion and love for the theatre caused them to look for sponsors to make their individual home video films. As producers, they hired the cast and crew, supervised and coordinated the planning, organizing and controlling of both the personnel and the fiscal resources for the productions. Mistura Asunmo (Mama 2D), Yetunde Ogunsola, Lanre Hassan, and Abiodun Duro-Ladipo have quite a number of titles to their credits - *Oyinbo Ajele*, *B'inaku*, *Esentaye*, *Ariyike*, *Apekanuko* and many more. While some were busy producing films, Iyabo Ogunsola faced the production of songs, chants and prayers into audio format.

Abiodun became a manager by the act of providence when her husband died at a young age in 1978, thus making her the third female theatre manager in the history of Nigerian theatre after Adunni Oluwole and Funmilayo Ranko who were a forerunner of her husband and contemporary respectively. But she was the first woman to take up the running of a husband's troupe for many years. Abiodun claims that she had an agreement with her husband to help his name stand the test of time and this made her to quickly end her mourning period by leading her husband's troupe on to produce some old productions and some other new ones. As soon as she assumed these roles of Producer and Director of the troupe, *Oba Koso* was taken on tour of schools, towns and cities but when it became cumbersome moving production materials and cast around without any support from the government or individuals; she decided to produce for the Nigerian Television Authority (NTA) Ibadan. First, in 1979, she recorded a thirteen episodic presentation of her songs and dances and in 1981, *B'inaku* (when fire dies, the ashes still remains which connotatively means that Duro Ladipo's theatre is still alive.), and a drama series was produced for the same station.

By the mid 80s, the singer and chanter joined in the alternative medium of video film when she produced *Oyinbo Ajele* (the British District Officer) for Broadcasting Corporation of Oyo State (BCOS); Ibadan, *Esentaye* in 1997, and

Ayelaagbe in 1998 for Galaxy Television. She also acted in Hubert Ogunde's *Aropin nT'enia* and Adeyemi Afolayan's *Ija Orogun*. She produced *Moremi* into a movie in 2009 while *Oba Koso* and *Ajagunnla* are still being showcased at festivals for keen lovers of live performances.

In staffing and keeping the artistes in the troupes, the women assist in recruiting more women by marrying more ladies for their husbands, getting and bringing cousins and siblings to join the theatre groups. Examples of this style of staffing is seen in Duro Ladipo National Theatre where Biodun Duro Ladipo brought her cousin popularly known as "Benja Benja" to play in one of the troupe's popular television series and Adeite Ogunde who brought her sister to work with Hubert Ogunde Theatre.

They also assisted in organizing rehearsals as attested to by two of the remaining pioneer members of Hubert Ogunde Theatre troupe, Tunbosun Odunsi who is popularly known as *Paadi* and Ayo Ogunsina (*Papalolo*). The men reminisced that the senior wives in Ogunde's household usually handled the rehearsals before Hubert himself joined to polish whatever they had done to his taste of readiness. Odunsi says "the women would have done sixty percent of the routine with the entire artistes (dancing, drumming, singing and acting) before Baba entered the hall."

Conclusion

Preparing a production is a group management effort and, therefore, requires careful attention to the changing, complex dynamics of the performers, designers, and production staff. The women might not make policies for the troupes, but they were responsible for their implementation which qualifies them as operational managers. As it was established in the family economic survival mindset that propelled them to do, motivation levels must, therefore, be maintained, conflicts must be resolved, and effective time-management skills were required for the show to be of high quality. The women developed these skills without formal education but learning on the job and they created successful performances that cannot be erased from theatre history in Nigeria.

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